The 18th Degree – Knight of the Rose Croix (Front)



The 18th Degree – Knight of the Rose Croix (Back)



The apron is white satin bordered with crimson on one side and black on the other. On the white side is embroidered the pelican side of the jewel. On the black side is a large red passion cross.

The cordon, worn from left to right, is of velvet or silk, crimson on one side and black on the other; it is plain on the crimson side. A red passion-cross is embroidered on the black side and worn over the heart. The colors of the cordon and apron, white and crimson, are symbols of light and the dawn of day and represent Faith, Hope, and Charity.

The jewel is the compasses with points opened to sixty degrees and resting on the segment of a graduated circle. On the lower part, on one side, is an eagle, with his wings extended and head lowered. Among the Egyptians the eagle was the emblem of a wise man because his wings bore him above the clouds into the purer atmosphere and nearer to the source of light, and his eyes were not dazzled with that light. Since the eagle also represented the great Egyptian Sun god

Amun-ra, it is a symbol of the infinite Supreme Reason or Intelligence. On the other side is a pelican, piercing its breast to feed its seven young in a nest under it. The pelican symbolizes every philanthropist and reformer who has offered up his life for the benefit of humanity, and so teaches us an exhaustless munificence toward all men, especially the needy and defenseless. It also represents the large and bountiful beneficence of nature, from whose bosom all created things draw their sustenance. Thus, the pelican and eagle together are symbols of perfect wisdom and perfect devotedness. There is a crimson cross showing on both sides; at the intersection of its arms, on the pelican side, is a crimson rose in bloom. The cross, pointing to the four cardinal directions, and whose arms, infinitely extended would never meet, is an emblem of space or infinity. The cross has been a sacred symbol in many cultures from the earliest antiquity. The rose was anciently sacred to the sun and to Aurora, Greek goddess of the dawn. As a symbol of the morning light, it represents resurrection and the renewal of life, and therefore immortality. Together the cross and rose symbolize immortality won by suffering and sorrow. On the summit of the compasses is an antique crown. On the segment of the circle, on the pelican side, is the word of this degree in special cipher. This jewel is of gold; the pelican and eagle upon it of silver.

DUTIES

Practice virtue that it may produce fruit. Labor to eliminate vice, purify humanity. Be tolerant of the faith and creed of others.

LESSONS

We should have faith in God, mankind and ourselves. We should hope in the victory over evil, the advancement of humanity, and a hereafter. Charity is relieving the wants and tolerating the errors and faults of others.

FOR REFLECTION

Do evil and calamity exist to provide an opportunity for the practice of virtue? Do your attitudes and actions reflect faith, hope and charity?

IMPORTANT SYMBOLS

The constellations called Faith, Hope and Charity, the punishments and terrors of Hell, the rose, the cross, the pelican, the eagle.

This degree sets forth the coming of the New Law, the Law of Love, proclaimed in unmistakable terms by Jesus of Nazareth after centuries of spiritual and intellectual darkness in the world when the Sacred Word was again lost. The supreme message brought to the world at that time was the proclamation of the Fatherhood of God and the Brotherhood of Man. This proclamation, though presented by a specific historical figure, is not to be taken as an advocation of a particular religious belief.

Tolerance is also taught as we are led through a myriad of examples from the many and diverse beliefs of the ancients which teach us that neither the cross as a symbol nor the notion of a messiah are uniquely Christian. They are manifestations of religious truths appropriate to the people who perceived them. From these examples, we may conclude that tolerance is not simply a duty, but an inescapable conclusion. The instructions on the concept of a messiah are suggestive only and are not to be taken as official doctrine or dogma of Freemasonry in general, or the Scottish Rite in particular; the religious test of Masonry is far too universal to admit of such a demand. As Pike says in the lecture of this degree, “No Mason has the right to interpret the symbols of this Degree for another, or to refuse him its mysteries, ...” (p. 290).

CEREMONY

As in the preceding obligatory degree, the 14th, there is no plot as such. The candidate is ushered through three apartments. The first depicts the world in chaos under the tyranny of evil. The officers sit on low stools among the shattered ruins of columns and the tools of the Symbolic Lodge. The officers convey dejection, sorrow and despair because the Sacred Word is again lost. The candidate enters this apartment lost in the mists of darkness, error and false philosophy—confused among the wrecks of the old system of thought. The

ebony crucifix (black, meaning evil, darkness) represents the world's treatment of those who strive to make known the truth. The Lost Word, one recalls, is representative of many things—the loss of reason, intellect and the moral sense and the loss of a true conception of Deity. In the world represented in this apartment, Man has made not only God, but the Devil, in his own image.

The candidate is asked if he will join the others who have labored in vain both day and night in the search for the Lost Word, the Key to the terrible labyrinth. Following the candidate's affirmative reply to enter into the search, three "constellations" appear- emblazoned on pillars: Faith, Hope and Charity—to lead the way out of the wilderness of doubt, dismay and despair.

The reference to the virtues of faith, hope and charity as "constellations" may admit of more than one interpretation; thus the following must be taken as only an example to stimulate the mind to greater reflection. In ancient times men believed that certain planets, stars and constellations and their positions in the heavens ruled over the affairs of men, bestowing beneficent or malignant tendencies in the course of fate that men might yield to or struggle against, often vainly. In Freemasonry men's lives are ruled, or should be, by constellations of virtue, sought for in the East—the source of light and thus knowledge. It is for this reason that the cover illustration of this book is an Eastern motif. Soon the constellations disappear and darkness rules again:

> *Thus it is that faith and distrust, and hope and doubt ever alternate, like day and night, and summer and winter.*

The search continues; the candidate travels around the lodge. In the north, the traditional place of darkness, the second apartment is encountered. The paintings or transparencies depict the punishments and terrors of Hell, such as those envisioned by Dante or Milton. The tableaus illustrating the consequences of sin and vice convey various levels of meaning and interpretation. To some, they are actual representations of the fate and punishment awaiting those who break God's laws; to others, they are just a symbol of earthly fate and punishment. But

to all, they should be a reminder of the law of cause and effect which cannot be repealed:

> *The word once spoken, the act once done, is spoken or done forever; and its consequences, good or evil, are immortal.*

More specifically, the flames symbolize the passions that infect the hearts of men against which Masonry has always warred.

The search continues for both the True Word and the explanation of the great enigma of the universe; namely, how to reconcile the existence of sin and wrong and pain and suffering in the world, the prosperity of the wicked and powerful, the untold wrongs and injustices, the emptiness and superficiality of some religious creeds. Why does evil exist: natural evil, such as famines, earthquakes and droughts, and moral evil, such as murder and tyranny?

During the search, we learn the Masonic meaning of the initials INRI inscribed upon the cross of Christ by artists as a representation of the actual message found in John 19:19. Nature is at once allegorical and factual, figurative and literal, symbolic and actual. It is a holy scripture of the Mason and upon it God has written His teachings for man to learn. Science is no enemy of religion but is rather the highest expression of religion- to know and understand the mysteries of God’s universe.

Man’s ability to express the concept of the infinite is its own evidence of the divine spark in the human intellect: numbers parade before us, unending but countable; space extends beyond our powers to see yet we patiently unravel its secrets one-by-one; the attributes of God are the infinite extensions of the virtues of man.

The hope of immortality is the beginning of religion. We see its evidence in the earliest cultures. All the major religions of the world promise immortality in the presence of God to justify virtue and the threat of immortality without God to inhibit vice. We teach that immortality is a natural consequence of the character of the soul itself, as Pike says:

The spirituality of the soul is the condition and necessary foundation of immortality; the law of merit and demerit the direct demonstration of it. The first is the metaphysical, the second the moral proof. Add to these the tendency of all the powers of the soul toward the Infinite, and the principle of final causes, and the proof of the immortality of the soul is complete (p. 706).

Reason separates mankind from the other forms of life; it is a gift. The spider may spin a beautiful web but it is not an artist; the bee may dance its messages but that is not ballet; termites construct large dwellings but they are not engineers. Man alone possesses the divine spark of intellect and therefore, reasons. The gift of reason is, however, no gift of ease and indulgence—it requires the greatest effort and thus is often dispensed with almost entirely. The great majority of mankind makes little or no use of this divine gift, choosing rather the simple life of physical labor occasionally punctuated by periods of time devoted to hobbies or passive recreation.

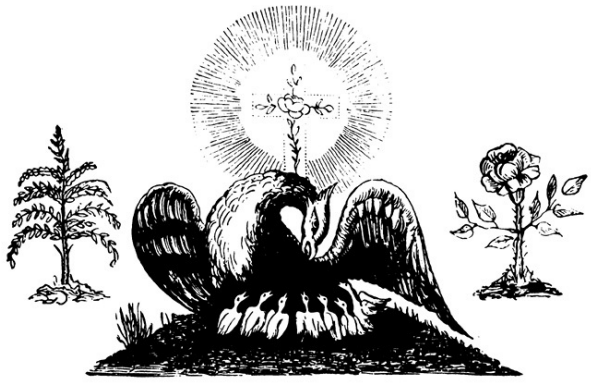
The third apartment represents the universe brilliant with the Supreme Deity's true light and freed from the principle of evil. In this chamber the instruction provides various interpretations for the existence of evil which have been created by philosophers and theologians of the past. Whether one chooses to accept the concept of evil as but the shadow of good or as the malignant influence of a personified principle of evil, such as Satan, or as the opportunity for the practice of virtue in the face of adversity, Masonry makes no judgment.

It is important to remember that not all of the great mysteries have been satisfactorily answered by the searching inquiries of man; and the existence of evil is such a mystery. Neither philosophy, religion nor Masonry have provided an answer to this great enigma that could be said to satisfy everyone. It is, for the moment, enough to recognize that both natural and moral evils exist and that much of this evil can be overcome by simple human exertion. Let those so inclined spend their time in the contemplation of such mysteries; it remains for the great majority of us simply to struggle against evil and make of this world the best of which we are capable. It is not for Masonry to make determinations

of truth about these interpretations, especially in this degree which teaches tolerance. When visiting this degree again, one should pay particular attention to these interpretations, so that each may find within them a meaning most closely aligned with his own beliefs. At the same time, you may be provided with the opportunity to reflect upon them further.

Also in this chamber the New Law of Love is recognized as the simple but sublime expression of the divine nature. Man discovers that God is not a tyrant, before whom men must abjectly tremble, but like a father, who is infinitely wise and good, merciful and loving.

Significant Symbolism



The symbolism here is composed of reminders from previous degrees, hints of future degrees and the symbols of the three great virtues taught in this degree—faith, hope and charity.

The Rose

Many mystical systems have found the rose an appealing symbol. Its use as a Masonic symbol is therefore but the continuation and expansion of an ancient tradition. In the Grecian Mysteries of Iacchus, the white rose was a symbol of silence, a virtue in the 4th Degree. In classical mythology the color of the red rose is attributed to a white rose being sprinkled by the blood of Venus injured by a thorn while hastening to aid her son Adonis who was attacked by a wild boar. Of course, there are other legends as well.

In Masonry, the rose has taken on the meaning of immortality. Surely the idea of immortality is as old as rational man. The Neanderthals buried their dead with

their possessions, possibly believing that the deceased would still have need of them. The most ancient mythologies speak of men made gods, to dwell forever in the heavens. Immortality is the quintessential hope of all mankind. For many it is the very source of virtue, for others only an absurd superstition; therefore, Masonry teaches only the hope of immortality, but still the literature of the Craft abounds with the expression of the soul's immortality and time has forged it into a creed, if not a doctrine.

Both references to the rose in the Bible, King James version, are suspect: the reference in Isaiah 35:1 reads 'lily' in the Latin Vulgate version of St. Jerome, and contemporary scholarship (for example, Anchor Bible) identifies 'the Rose of Sharon' in Song of Songs 2:1 as a crocus. All this notwithstanding, the rose became, in Christian symbolism, a representation of the blood of Christ. Its merger with the cross was virtually inevitable; and indeed we see just such on the coat-of-arms adopted by Martin Luther.

The Cross

The ancient manifestations of this symbol are, in general, reviewed by Pike in the lecture in *Morals and Dogma* and so we need not be detained by repetition. We might add, however, to Pike's observation that the cross was a sign of the Persian deity Mithra, that the mercenaries who revered this god were thus able to fight in the Christian emperor Constantine's army under a standard bearing this symbol since to them it represented light. We should also add to Pike's review in the lecture for this degree that the equal-armed cross was a symbol of the medieval alchemists for whom it represented the four elements: air, earth, fire and water (see diagram in *Morals and Dogma*, p. 791). Even in its more ancient representations, that is, pre-Christian, the cross may be associated with love as an integral part of the astrological symbol of Venus, the Roman deity of that virtue; the presence of similar cruciform representations as part of the symbols of Mercury, Mars, Jupiter and Saturn make this less telling than it might first appear but equally attests to the diversity of the symbolic meanings of the cross.

The cross in Masonry is a statement of infinity. This concept, and the word we use to describe it, contains within the borders of its meaning some of the most profound thoughts of both philosophy and science. It stretches our minds to the limits of human comprehension, conjuring up visions of numbers stretching endlessly before us, a universe which has no bounds, time extending without limit before and behind us, and, above all, the overwhelming attributes of God. The idea of the infinity of the attributes of God may be impossible for man to comprehend but the pursuit of such understanding is its own noble work.

The Pelican

This symbol derives directly from early Christian art and represented Christ. As a Christian symbol, it has its origin in the belief that the pelican pecked at its breast to feed its young with its blood; hence it was seen as an apt representation of Christ shedding his blood for the redemption of His children, all mankind. Thus, this symbol is generalized to signify devotedness.

The pelican also is symbolic of nature. We are reminded in *Morals and Dogma* that none of the magnificent works of man can compare with the wonders of the natural world; no beauty is as sublime, no perfection so apparent. The very commonness of our surroundings dulls our senses to this wonder and we may become bored, even cynical, about the beauties of nature. The old adage “stop and smell the flowers” should remind us of what we are missing when we let the distractions and cares of the world blind us to the beauty and order of our surroundings, God’s gift to our senses.”

The Eagle

Like the rose, this emblem is of great antiquity figuring in the symbolic inventory of: the Egyptians, as the sun; the Hebrews, Jehovah; the Romans, wisdom. The Christians saw the eagle, like the pelican, as a representation of Christ who bore upon his wings His children teaching them, by example, truth and love and bearing them upward to a more spiritual conception of life. To Pike it also signified liberty, probably because of its presence on the Great Seal of the

United States; the bald eagle having been selected rather than Ben Franklin's suggestion of the turkey.

As wisdom is attained through reason, the eagle is also symbolic of reason, the unique attribute of man among all the world's creatures. By reason, we have come to understand the mechanics of the natural world, established societies bound by custom and law, created great works of literature and art, fathomed many of the mysteries of the human mind and secured at least a cursory understanding of the nature of Deity and our place in the universal plan. It remains for us to marshal its power to better ends, to alleviate human misery and suffering, end the scourge of war and loose the shackles of vice.

The Pillars

For Pike, faith corresponds with beauty, that attribute which is one of the supports of the Symbolic Lodge. We may also see it as a symbol of one of the major teachings of this degree: the unity, immutability and goodness of God.

Similarly, hope is said to represent strength, to which we may attach the teaching of the immortality of the soul, perhaps the supreme hope of mankind.

And finally, charity is said to signify wisdom, embodied here in the teaching of the concept of a redeemer which, of whatever religion, is the ultimate manifestation of God's love for man.

Besides the three theological virtues of faith, hope and charity, we must not lose sight of those truly Masonic virtues- brotherly love, relief and truth- taught us in the Symbolic Lodge. Two symbols in this degree represent the fraternity itself, the pelican and the rose and cross united. The pelican representing the Masonic virtue of relief and the rosy cross the Masonic virtue of brotherly love. The Masonic virtue of truth is represented by the Lost Word itself.

LECTURE

The compelling instructions of this degree are faith, hope and charity. Allied with these virtues is tolerance.

There are many fragments in this series of quotes. The intent is that the entire collection will be seen as an outline of the lecture which should be read in its entirety as soon as practicable. Here, perhaps more than elsewhere, we should apply Pike's injunction that a man is not fully invested with a degree until he has read its lecture in *Morals and Dogma*.

Tolerance:

... whenever the door of any Degree is closed against him who believes in one God and the soul's immortality, on account of the other tenets of his faith, that Degree is Masonry no longer (p. 290).

No one Mason has the right to measure for another, within the walls of a Masonic Temple, the degree of veneration which he shall feel for any Reformer, or the Founder of any Religion (p. 308).

Masonry also has her mission to perform. With her traditions reaching back to the earliest times, and her symbols dating further back than even the monumental history of Egypt extends, she invites all men of all religions to enlist under her banners to war against evil, ignorance and wrong. You are now her Knight! To her service your sword is consecrated. May you prove a worthy soldier in a worthy cause! (p. 311).

Faith:

Exalt and magnify Faith as we will, and say that it begins where Reason ends, it must, after all, have a foundation, either in Reason, Analogy, the Consciousness, or human testimony (p. 301).

...after all, Faith must flow out from some source within us, when the evidence of that which we are to believe is not presented to our senses ... (p. 301) .

Faith is the veiled Isis, the Supplement of Reason, in the shadows, which precede or follow Reason. It emanates from the Reason, but can never confound it nor be confounded with it. The encroachments of Reason upon Faith, or of Faith on

Reason, are eclipses of the Sun or Moon; when they occur, they make useless both the Source of Light and its reflection, at once (p. 306).

Faith—as Beauty:

...there is no beauty like a firm faith in God, our fellows and ourself (p. 288).

Faith—that Evil will be overcome:

But not to all is Faith sufficient to overcome this great difficulty [the existence of natural and moral evil] (p. 300).

The trials of life are the blessings of life, to the individual or the Nation, if either has a Soul that is truly worthy of salvation (p. 307).

Hope:

... at the appointed time, He will redeem and regenerate the world ... (p. 308).

Hope—as Strength:

He only is strong who is hopeful;... (p. 308).

Charity:

[God is] *... a Father, loving the creatures He has made, with a love immeasurable and exhaustless; Who feels for us, and sympathizes with us, and sends us pain and want and disaster only that they may serve to develop in us the virtues and excellences that befit us to live with Him hereafter* (p. 309).

Charity—as Wisdom:

... he only is wise who judges others charitably; ... (p. 288).

Charity—of a Redeemer:

Greater love hath no man than this, that a man lay down his life for his friend [John 15:13; quoted by Pike, p. 310].

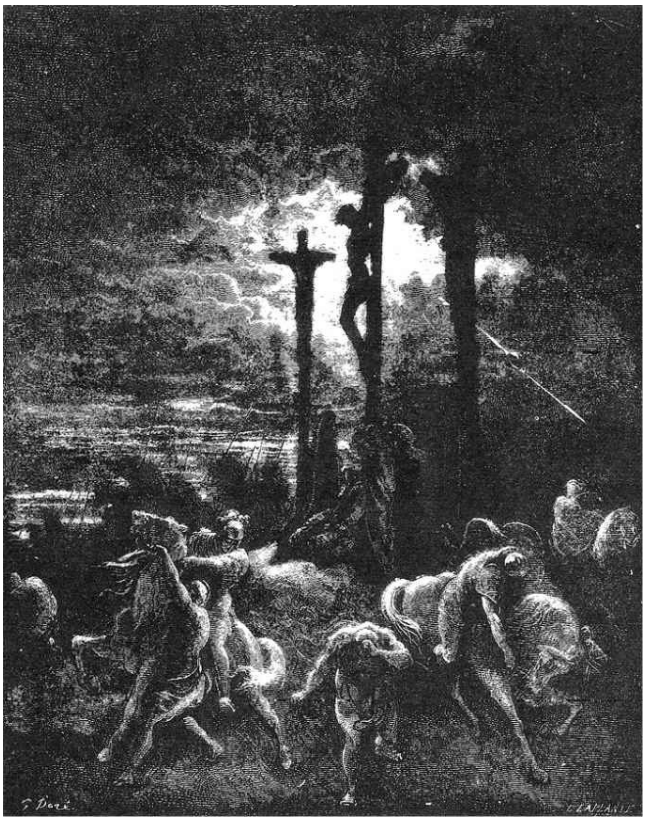
As a lover of all mankind, laying down His [Jesus'] *life for the emancipation of His Brethren, He should be to all, to Christian, to Jew, and to Mahometan, an object of gratitude and veneration* (p. 308).

The Gospel of Love He sealed with His life (p. 310).

Faith, Hope & Charity:

The Eagle is to us the symbol of Liberty, the Compasses of Equality, the Pelican of Humanity, and our order of Fraternity. Laboring for these, with Faith, Hope and Charity as our armor, we will wait with patience for the final triumph of Good and the complete manifestation of the Word of God (p. 308).

That God is good and merciful, and loves and sympathizes with the creatures He has made; ... that all men are our brothers, whose wants we are to supply, their errors to pardon, their opinions to tolerate, their injuries to forgive; that man has an immortal soul, a free will, a right to freedom of thought and action; that all men are equal in God's sight; that we best serve God by humility, meekness, gentleness, kindness, and the other virtues which the lowly can practise as well as the lofty; this is the new Law, the Word... (p. 310).



Close of the Crucifixion
by Gustav Dore